

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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SESSION FOUR

Lament, Grief, and Honest Prayer

Day 2, afternoon

Before you begin

You have had a real break since Session Three. If you have not, take one now. This session should not be entered tired, hungry, or directly on the heels of the handing-over exercise.

This session may bring grief or anger closer to the surface, but that is not something you must force. Its purpose is to give honest, prayerful expression to what you can safely acknowledge today. Please read the boundaries before you start. You are in charge of how far you go. You may stop at any point, and you may leave anything untouched.

If you have a trauma history and exercises involving memory, grief, or silence tend to trigger panic, flashbacks, dissociation, or severe distress, use the supported format or plan this session with a qualified trauma-informed professional. A designated friend can be a steadying presence but is not necessarily equipped to manage a trauma reaction. If your loss is very recent, traumatic, or currently overwhelming your ability to function, you may skip this session entirely and choose simple companionship, rest, or supported prayer instead. You do not need to process a major loss according to the retreat's timetable.

Have tissues nearby. It is not a sign of anything; it is practical.

Central passage

Psalm 13

It is six verses. Read it three times: once quickly, once slowly, and once noticing where the psalm turns.

Teaching

Depending on how they are classified, laments make up roughly a third of the Psalms and are often described as the Psalter's largest category. That is worth pausing over. The book that has shaped Jewish and Christian prayer for centuries contains far more complaint, grief, protest, and unanswered questioning than many Christians expect, and God kept all of it. Whatever you have been taught, explicitly or by example, about keeping your prayers positive, the psalmists were not taught it.

Psalm 13 is a lament in miniature, and it displays a common lament movement: address, complaint, petition, and renewed trust. Not every biblical lament contains every movement or places them in the same order, but this one shows the shape clearly. It begins by addressing God directly: "How long, O LORD?" Four times in two verses the psalmist asks how long, and the questions are not polite. Will you forget me forever? Will you hide your face? Must I carry sorrow all day? Must my enemy win? Then it turns to petition: consider me, answer me, light up my eyes. And then, in the final two verses, it turns again, to trust: "But I have trusted in your steadfast love... I will sing to the LORD, because he has dealt bountifully with me."

Notice what the psalm does not do. It does not skip the first four verses to get to the last two. It does not apologise for the questions. In the poem, the declaration of trust comes after

complaint and petition. That does not necessarily mean the pain has ended. It shows that trust can be spoken while the situation remains unresolved, and that it is a decision as much as a feeling: "I have trusted." Address, complaint, petition, trust. That is a pattern, and it is a permission.

Not every lament reaches the trust. **Psalm 88** ends, "You have caused my beloved and my friend to shun me; my companions have become darkness." No turn, no resolution, no song. Chapter 4 mentioned it, and it belongs here as well. Scripture makes room for prayer that ends in the dark. If your lament today does not reach the final verses of Psalm 13, you have not prayed wrongly. Your prayer may resemble Psalm 88 in ending without visible resolution, and that kind of prayer is also in the book.

Grief in particular needs this permission, because much of what people carry into a retreat is grief they have never had time or permission to feel. Some of it is the obvious kind: a death, a diagnosis, a divorce, a miscarriage. But much of it is less visible. The ministry that did not become what you hoped. The marriage that is not what you prayed for. The friendship that faded without a reason. The version of yourself you expected to be by now. The child who has walked away from faith. The church that hurt you. The body that no longer does what it did. These losses often have no funeral and no casserole, and so they are carried privately, sometimes for years, as a heaviness with no name.

Jesus wept at the tomb of Lazarus (John 11:35). John does not fully explain everything contained in his tears; grief, compassion, and indignation at death may all be present. But the scene shows that the coming resurrection did not make tears inappropriate in the presence of death and human sorrow. And on the cross, Jesus prayed the opening words of Psalm 22, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Mark 15:34), entering the language of lament at the height of his suffering. The psalm itself eventually

moves toward vindication, but Jesus did not skip its cry of abandonment. If lament was appropriate for him, it is appropriate for you.

One more thing, because some readers need to hear it. Scripture permits us to bring anger, protest, confusion, and even accusation directly to God rather than disguising them with religious language. At the end of Job, God rebuked Job's friends and said Job had spoken rightly in a way they had not (Job 42:7); yet Job also acknowledged the limits of his understanding (Job 42:3–6). Together, these passages make room for honest protest without suggesting that every accusation made in grief is a complete description of God. Jeremiah used startling language, telling God that he felt deceived or overpowered (Jeremiah 20:7, depending on translation). The psalmists asked whether God was asleep (Psalm 44:23). Honest prayer does not mean that every conclusion we draw about God is correct. It means we bring the real conclusion to him, where it can be heard, challenged, and transformed.

Anger that cannot be acknowledged may deepen isolation. Bringing it to God can be a beginning. But if you cannot yet do that, your silence does not place you beyond grace. You may need the presence of another person before words become possible.

Self-assessment

In your journal, gently:

1. Is there a loss in your life that has received little space, support, or acknowledgment? Name it in a word or a phrase, or in a general word if a specific one is too much.
2. Is there something about which you feel angry, disappointed, confused, or abandoned in relation to God? Write it down without softening it.

3. When you read Psalm 13's questions, which one is closest to your own: forgetting, hiding, sorrow, an enemy prevailing, or another phrase from the psalm?
4. What have you been told, or told yourself, about whether it is acceptable to pray like this? If any answer brings up more than you can hold, stop here, and use the pause guidance from Chapter 5. You can return to the rest of the session later, or not at all.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit your experience. Change or omit the others.

*God, I have been carrying grief I did not have time to
feel, and anger I did not think I was allowed to say.
You kept the laments.
You kept Psalm 88.
Help me risk bringing you one honest question.
How long?
I do not understand why _____.
I am tired of _____.
I have lost _____, and I have not been able to say so
until now.
Consider me.
Answer me.
Light up my eyes.
I do not have the last verses yet.
Meet me in the first four.
Amen.*

Fill in the blanks aloud or silently, or leave them empty if the words will not come.

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes. This is deliberately shorter than the previous session. If you are already at capacity, five minutes is enough, or none.

Anchor phrase: **"How long, O LORD?"** Or, if that is too raw today: **"Consider and answer me."**

Do not try to feel anything in this silence, and do not try to stop feeling anything. If tears come, let them. If nothing comes, that is also permitted. God's presence is not suspended until your grief becomes orderly or your prayer reaches a hopeful conclusion.

If the silence becomes more than sorrow, if it moves into panic, disconnection, or a sense of reliving rather than remembering, stop, open your eyes, and use the orientation exercise from Chapter 5. Contact your support person if you need to. If the reaction is severe, persistent, or includes danger to yourself, contact a qualified professional, crisis service, or emergency service rather than relying only on your designated person.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What did you find yourself grieving, or angry about, during the silence? Write it in whatever detail feels safe.
2. Psalm 13 moves through address, complaint, petition, and trust. Which of those four have you been skipping in your own prayers? Which have you been stuck in?
3. What loss have you felt unable or unwilling to grieve openly, because you believed you should be past it, or because hope

seemed to forbid sorrow? Tears are one expression of grief, not the measure of whether grief is real.

4. Write one sentence that begins "God, I do not understand why..." and finish it truthfully.

Practical exercise: writing your own lament

Choose your level before you begin. All three are complete exercises.

- **Brief lament:** one sentence of complaint and one request.
 - **General lament:** the four parts below, using broad words without names or details.
 - **Full lament:** the four parts below, in whatever detail feels safe and appropriate. Using Psalm 13 as a template, write a lament of your own. It does not need to be long, and it does not need to be poetic.
1. **Address.** Speak to God directly, by whatever name is yours for him.
 2. **Complaint.** Say what is wrong. Be specific if you can be safely, general if you cannot. Ask "how long?" if that is your question. Do not soften it, and do not add "but I know you have a plan" unless you actually mean it in this moment.
 3. **Petition.** Ask for what you want, not for what you think you should want. The psalmist asked for his eyes to be lit up so that he would not die. You may tell God even the desire you know is confused, impossible, or wrong. Naming a desire is not endorsing it, and writing it does not give permission to act upon harm. If you feel at risk of harming yourself or someone else, stop and seek immediate help.
 4. **Trust.** If you can write a confident statement of trust, write it. If you cannot, leave the space blank, write "not yet," or name the smallest truth you can still hold: "I am still speaking," "I

want to believe," "I do not know how to leave." Addressing God honestly may itself be the only trust available today, and Psalm 88 gives you that permission. A blank fourth part is an honest lament, not a failed one. When it is written, read it to God, aloud if you have privacy. Then keep it. Do not tear it up. This is a prayer, and you may want it again. Some people find that returning to their lament weeks later shows them how far they have moved, or shows them that the fourth part has quietly written itself.

If the writing opens something you did not expect, stop when you need to. You do not have to finish the lament today. An unfinished lament is still prayer.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

*I have spoken as honestly as I can today.
My grief does not disqualify me from God's presence.
I do not have to be finished with sorrow in order to
pray.
Where trust is difficult, I am willing to remain with one
honest word, or to receive support until words return.*

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

After Session Four: rest. This has been the hardest hour of the retreat for many people, and the next session, on confession and grace, should not follow it immediately. The default is to leave Session Five until the following morning. If, after a long break, a meal, a walk, and time outside, you feel settled enough to continue this evening, you may, but do not assume you should.

Session Six, on forgiveness, may also be deferred to the at-home format or to the weeks after the retreat, and Part Four shows how the remaining sessions rearrange when you do that. The order of the sessions matters more than the clock, and your capacity matters more than completing all ten in three days.

A word for readers whose grief is heavy or very recent. You do not need to wait until grief has lasted a particular length of time or become unbearable before seeking support. Consider professional or group support if you are struggling to function, becoming increasingly depressed or anxious, relying on harmful coping strategies, experiencing persistent panic or traumatic reactions, or simply feel that you should not carry this alone.

If today has left you with thoughts of not wanting to be alive, follow Chapter 5 now. If you may act on those thoughts, have formed a plan, or cannot keep yourself safe, contact local emergency services or go to the nearest emergency department. Ask a trusted person to stay with you while help is arranged. Do not remain alone, and do not continue the retreat.